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Environmental Working Group: How Food Became a 'Flavor Business' - A History of Ultra-processed Food

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WASHINGTON, July 23 -- The Environmental Working Group issued the following research:

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How food became a 'flavor business': A history of ultra-processed food

By Sarah Reinhardt, MPH, RDN (EWG), Adam Levin and Luz Fontana-Mansilla, Communications interns

Ultra-processed foods, or UPF, have flooded our food supply while undermining public health. Today, an estimated 70% of all packaged food sold in the U.S. is ultra-processed.

UPF make up more than half the typical adult's diet and nearly two-thirds of children's diets. Experts agree these foods are a leading driver of chronic illnesses like type 2 diabetes, heart disease, depression and cancer.

It's not an accident that UPF are widely available, affordable and even addictive. Food companies made them this way, taking tactics straight from the tobacco industry - and the U.S. has failed to regulate them at every turn.

Big Tobacco made food its business

At the turn of the 20th century, highly processed foods were a novelty. During the World Wars, they became a necessity, as the U.S. found ways to get food to soldiers without spoiling.

But what happened next turned them into a business model. Beginning in the early 1960s, tobacco conglomerates started expanding aggressively into the food industry. They shifted their marketing expertise and resources, honed over years of selling cigarettes, to the food industry. An internal memo noted they were not just in the tobacco business, but the "flavor business."

Cheap ultraprocessed foods flooded grocery stores. By 2001, grocery foods were 2.4 times more likely to be "hyperpalatable," compared to 1988.

It was a lucrative play. Profits soared as corporations engineered foods designed to capture consumers and keep them coming back for more.

Meanwhile, evidence linking UPF to many adverse health outcomes mounted, and experts started to see their addictive potential.

The U.S. has resisted UPF regulation

More than a dozen countries have mandated front-of-package warning labels for foods high in sodium, fats and sugars - a first step towards helping people choose healthier foods. But the U.S. government has made no such changes.

Now, states are taking initiative in limiting and banning UPF. In 2025, California became the first state to ban UPF from school meals and proposed non-UPF certification labels for consumer products. Other states are following suit (see EWG's interactive food tracker to find out more about state action).

Yet even as the 2026 Dietary Guidelines call for dramatic cuts in consumption of highly processed foods, the Food and Drug Administration missed its own deadline for defining UPF - and failed to implement any meaningful regulation of these foods.

EWG's timeline shows the key events in the history of ultra-processed food and explains how it became so deeply embedded in our food supply.

Pre-World War II

Industrially formulated, artificial ingredients first appear in the food supply.

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1879

Saccharin, 100 times sweeter than table sugar, is invented in a Baltimore laboratory by accident.

SOURCE (https://www.acs.org/molecule-of-the-week/archive/s/saccharin.html)

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1885

The first iteration of Coca-Cola syrup is made with cocaine extracts and marketed as a medical remedy for "nerves."

SOURCE (https://www.seriouseats.com/history-of-jell-o-salad)

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1921

Wonder Bread debuts as one of the first pre-sliced commercial breads, a major step in the rise of convenience-oriented, industrial food production.

SOURCE (https://www.smithsonianmag.com/smart-news/the-life-and-death-of-wonder-bread-129979401/?)

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1937

The canned meat Spam is invented. It would later be used to feed soldiers and local residents during periods of wartime occupation, gaining massive popularity.

SOURCE (https://www.today.com/food/spam-midwestern-canned-meat-hawaiian-staple-today-t214417?cid=sm_npd_td_fb_ma&fbclid=IwAR1WIBQ42a_YLqsGxDpskqH65jvNcwj2_8W4tLLErJLzs8IFlagVoD_VG9w)

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WWII-1950s

During World War II, the need to feed soldiers prompts the invention of new ingredients and processing techniques. They are eventually adapted for consumer use.

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1943

Shelf-stable cheese, invented decades earlier, is refined and used to feed soldiers.

SOURCE (https://www.wired.com/2015/08/us-military-helped-invent-cheetos/)

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1948

The Frito-Lay company develops Cheetos with powdered cheese used by the military and a mix of bright artificial colors and flavors.

SOURCE (https://www.wired.com/2015/08/us-military-helped-invent-cheetos/)

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1952

The first diet soda, No-Cal, is created using calcium cyclamate -- an ingredient that the FDA will ban 17 years later.

SOURCE (https://www.thetakeout.com/1775417/who-invented-diet-soda-history/)

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1952

Wonder Bread boasts in ads that its products contain as much protein as roast beef and help people grow "bigger and stronger."

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1960s-1990s

As the tobacco industry faces growing regulation, some of its largest members start acquiring food companies. Tobacco research and marketing strategies are used to develop new foods.

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1962

The tobacco industry sees the need for diversification. An internal memo from R.J. Reynolds, one of the nation's largest cigarette makers, argues for entering the food sector. The company says it is not just in the tobacco business but in the "flavor business."

SOURCE (https://www.industrydocuments.ucsf.edu/all-industries/documents/viewer/?iid=hmxn0096&id=hmxn0096&db-set=documents&industry=all-industries&rtool=metadata)

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1963

R.J. Reynolds acquires Pacific Hawaiian Products Company, the producer of Hawaiian Punch. The sale marks the U.S. tobacco industry's initial move into the food sector.

SOURCE (https://www.nytimes.com/1963/02/09/archives/reynolds-buys-pacific-hawaiian-purchase-price-is-reported-to-run.html)

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1970

Americans' consumption of sugar - in high quantities often a characteristic of UPF - doubles in the first three-quarters of the century.

SOURCE (https://onlinestatbook.com/2/case_studies/sugar.html?)

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1973

The Federal Trade Commission finds Wonder Bread has falsely advertised its product as causing children to grow dramatically.

SOURCE (https://www.nytimes.com/1973/11/06/archives/false-advertising-of-wonder-bread-charged-by-ftc.html)

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1977

Regulators deny a request by consumer protection groups asking them to ban the marketing of sugary foods to children.

SOURCE (https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2025/10/16/well/eat/ultraprocessed-food-junk-history.html)

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1983

The FTC reverses restrictions on the marketing of food as "natural," paving the way for advertisers to promote highly processed products as health foods.

SOURCE (https://www.nytimes.com/1982/06/13/us/ftc-urged-to-drop-proposed-rules-on-food-ads.html)

SOURCE (https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10787032/)

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1985

R.J. Reynolds' $4.9 billion acquisition of Nabisco Brands signals Big Tobacco's strategy shift to consolidate the packaged food market.

SOURCE (https://www.nytimes.com/1985/06/03/business/rj-reynolds-set-to-pay-4.9-billion-in-bid-for-nabisco.html)

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1985

Tobacco company Phillip Morris, a rival of R.J. Reynolds, purchases General Foods, the producer of Jell-O and Kool-Aid, for $5.8 billion.

SOURCE (https://www.nytimes.com/1985/09/28/business/philip-morris-to-buy-general-foods-for-5.8-billion.html)

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1988

Phillip Morris purchases Kraft Foods for $13.1 billion and merges with General Foods to create Kraft General Foods, the largest food corporation in North America and second largest in the world.

SOURCE (https://www.nytimes.com/1988/10/31/business/kraft-being-sold-to-philip-morris-for-13.1-billion.html)

SOURCE (https://www.nytimes.com/1988/10/31/business/kraft-being-sold-to-philip-morris-for-13.1-billion.html)

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1996

Kraft Foods determines that 30% to 35% of Kool-Aid and Tang consumption is by Black and Latino communities. The company also outlines marketing strategies targeting these groups in an internal memo.

SOURCE (https://www.industrydocuments.ucsf.edu/all-industries/documents/viewer/?iid=zpmx0041&id=zpmx0041&db-set=documents&industry=all-industries&rtool=metadata)

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1997

The FDA makes it easier for food and chemical companies to approve their own additives as generally regarded as safe, or GRAS - a category originally created to approve basic cooking ingredients like vinegar and spices. The "GRAS loophole" becomes a way for many chemicals to enter into the marketplace without adequate safety review.

SOURCE (https://www.nyu.edu/about/news-publications/news/2024/august/legal-loophole-unsafe-ingredients.html)

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1999

Amid growing concerns over tobacco-related lawsuits, RJR Nabisco Holdings separates its food business, Nabisco, into Nabisco Group Holdings. Soon after, Phillip Morris buys Nabisco.

SOURCE (https://journalrecord.com/1999/06/16/rj-reynolds-completes-spinoff/)

SOURCE (https://www.npr.org/2000/06/26/1075909/nabisco-philip-morris)

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1999

In internal documents, Kraft Foods refers to its race- and ethnicity-based campaigns borrowed from cigarette marketing as "fully integrated," that is, they combine direct advertising, philanthropy and community partnerships to maximize UPF marketing.

SOURCE (https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC7002936/)

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2000s-2010s

Carlos Monteiro coins the term "ultra-processed food." Research links UPF to chronic diseases. The U.S. resists calls for regulation, even as other countries take action.

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2001

Esteemed medical journal the Lancet finds an association between obesity and addiction. During the next 10 years, cutting-edge brain imaging techniques will link sugar and hyperpalatable foods to brain dopamine systems.

SOURCE (https://doi.org/10.1016/s0140-6736%2800%2903643-6)

SOURCE (https://doi.org/10.1038/nn.2519)

SOURCE (https://doi.org/10.1016/j.neubiorev.2007.04.019)

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2004

In a confidential letter to the director general of the World Health Organization, the federal government rejects a proposed scientific link between highly processed food and obesity.

SOURCE (https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC318478/pdf/bmj32800185.pdf)

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2009

Brazilian epidemiologist Carlos Monteiro coins the term "ultra-processed food" and introduces his four-part NOVA classification system, which categorizes foods by the extent of their industrial processing.

SOURCE (https://www.cambridge.org/core/services/aop-cambridge-core/content/view/0C514FC9DB264538F83D5D34A81BB10A/S1368980009005291a.pdf/nutrition-and-health-the-issue-is-not-food-nor-nutrients-so-muchas-processing.pdf)

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2011

Monteiro applies the NOVA system to household food purchasing data in Brazil and shows a decades-long increase in consumption of highly processed foods with lower nutritional quality.

SOURCE (https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/public-health-nutrition/article/increasing-consumption-of-

ultraprocessed-foods-and-likely-impact-on-human-health-evidence-from-brazil/C36BB4F83B90629DA15CB0A3CBEBF6FA)

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2013

A Congressional Research Service report finds that during economic downturns, prices for less-processed foods increase more rapidly than those for highly processed foods, making it more difficult for low-income consumers to access healthy options.

SOURCE (https://www.congress.gov/crs_external_products/R/PDF/R40545/R40545.20.pdf)

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2014

A large cross-sectional study in Brazil is the first to link household availability of UPF to obesity.

SOURCE

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2014

Brazil becomes the first country to issue national dietary guidance to avoid ultra-processed foods.

SOURCE (https://www.foodpolitics.com/wp-content/uploads/Brazilian-Dietary-Guidelines-2014.pdf)

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2014

Ecuador adopts mandatory "traffic light" nutrient labels that may appear on the front, back or side of packaged products. The labels classify foods using red, yellow or green lights based on sodium, sugar, fat or saturated fat content. Other countries will implement similar labels in the next decade.

SOURCE (http://globalfoodresearchprogram.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/01/GFRP-UNC_FOPL_maps_2026-Jan.pdf)

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2015

A study supported by the National Institute on Drug Abuse finds not all foods are equally implicated in compulsive eating behavior, and highly processed foods appear to be particularly associated with "food addiction."

SOURCE (https://journals.plos.org/plosone/article/file?id=10.1371/journal.pone.0117959&type=printable)

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2016

Chile enacts the first legislation requiring front-of-package warning labels, using black octagons to mark foods high in saturated fat, sugar, salt and calories. Argentina, Brazil, Canada, Colombia, Mexico, Peru, Uruguay and Venezuela

will adopt similar labels.

SOURCE (https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC7012389/)

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2018

Using data from the NutriNet-Sante cohort in France, a large prospective study finds a 10% increase in the proportion of UPF in the diet is linked to a 10% or greater risk of cancer.

SOURCE (https://hal.science/hal-02178347)

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2018

The director of the National Institute on Drug Abuse releases a study based on brain imaging showing sugar triggers reward centers and compulsive behaviors similar to those of addictive drugs.

SOURCE (https://storage.imrpress.com/imr/journal/FBL/article/490162/1752760534662.pdf)

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2019

Two major studies add to findings about UPF. One connects diets high in UPF with a higher risk of all-cause mortality. The other links UPF to increased cardiovascular disease risk.

SOURCE (https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/31142450/)

SOURCE (https://www.bmj.com/content/365/bmj.l1451)

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2019

The National Institutes of Health publishes the first randomized controlled study on UPF, which finds that diets higher in UPF are associated with consumption of 500 calories more per day and weight gain.

SOURCE (https://www.cell.com/action/showPdf?pii=S1550-4131%2819%2930248-7)

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2020-present

Research cements the scientific basis for health harms of UPF and adds to evidence of potential addiction. In the absence of federal action, states like California take the lead.

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2020

A NutriNet-Sante cohort study shows a significant association between UPF consumption and Type 2 diabetes.

SOURCE (https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/31841598/)

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2020

A study from the American Journal of Public Health finds tobacco executives directly transferred race- and ethnicity-based marketing strategies to the food industry.

SOURCE (https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC7002936/#bib129)

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2021

Experts publish the most comprehensive scientific review to date of UPF addiction, shaping a new wave of addiction research.

SOURCE (https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/34152831/)

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2021

Massachusetts introduces the first piece of legislation that would define UPF and limit them in school lunches. The bill fails in a state House committee.

SOURCE (https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10787032/)

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2023

From 2009 to 2023, global UPF sales rise from $1.5 trillion to $1.9 trillion. UPF now make up nearly two-thirds - 62% - of all calories consumed by youth and more than half, or 53%, of all calories consumed by adults.

SOURCE (https://www.thelancet.com/journals/lancet/article/PIIS0140-6736%2825%2901567-3/abstract)

SOURCE (https://www.cdc.gov/nchs/products/databriefs/db536.htm)

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2023

Rio de Janeiro prohibits the sale of ultra-processed foods in schools.

SOURCE (https://desiderata.org.br/noticias/rio-de-janeiro-on-the-road-to-healthier-schools/)

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2023

Colombia introduces the world's first explicit tax targeting ultra-processed foods.

SOURCE (https://www.bmj.com/content/383/bmj.p2698)

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2024

A combined review of 45 meta-analyses - the largest review of evidence to date - presents evidence that UPF are linked to 32 different markers of health. Diets high in UPF are associated with a 50% increase in the risk of death from cardiovascular disease and a 48% increase in the risk of anxiety.

SOURCE (https://www.bmj.com/content/384/bmj-2023-077310)

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2024

The first lawsuit brought against big UPF companies alleges their food led to diagnoses in a 16-year-old of multiple chronic diseases. The case is dismissed.

SOURCE (https://www.arnoldporter.com/en/perspectives/advisories/2025/12/the-latest-litigation-threat-targeting-upfs)

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2025

Under an EWG-sponsored law, California becomes the first state to develop a legal definition of UPF and begins to phase out the most harmful from public K-12 school meals.

SOURCE (https://leginfo.legislature.ca.gov/faces/billNavClient.xhtml?bill_id=202520260AB1264)

SOURCE (https://www.ewg.org/news-insights/news-release/2025/09/california-lawmakers-pass-first-nation-bill-protect-kids-harmful)

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2025

New estimates indicate nearly three-quarters of food in the U.S. food supply is ultra-processed.

SOURCE (https://www.nature.com/articles/s41467-023-37457-1)

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2025

San Francisco brings the first government lawsuit against 10 UPF manufacturers, citing the healthcare burden created by chronic disease.

SOURCE (https://www.theguardian.com/society/2025/dec/02/ultra-processed-foods-lawsuit-san-francisco)

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2025

The Lancet publishes a series of papers establishing ultra-processed food as a public health priority and urging unified global action, including policies aimed at UPF production, marketing and consumption.

SOURCE (https://www.thelancet.com/series-do/ultra-processed-food)

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2026

The Trump administration's 2025-2030 Dietary Guidelines recommend eating less highly processed foods.

An EWG analysis finds almost all new food chemicals enter the food supply without federal safety review.

SOURCE (https://cdn.realfood.gov/DGA.pdf)

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2026

The FDA sets - and fails to meet - an April deadline to define UPF.

SOURCE (https://www.food-safety.com/articles/11207-rfk-jr-says-federal-ultra-processed-foods-definition-is-coming-in-april)

SOURCE (https://www.politico.com/news/2026/04/21/diamantas-ultra-processed-foods-definition-00884169)

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2026

California Assembly Member Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino) introduces legislation creating a voluntary "Non-Ultraprocessed Certified" label for non-ultra-processed foods.

SOURCE (https://legiscan.com/CA/bill/AB2244/2025)

SOURCE (https://www.ewg.org/news-insights/news-release/2026/05/california-state-assembly-advances-bill-create-landmark-non)

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2026

A landmark issue of the American Journal of Public Health spotlights tobacco companies' use of technology and marketing tactics to shape ultra-processed food production. It also adds new evidence of the health harms of UPF, including increased risk of dementia.

SOURCE (https://ajph.aphapublications.org/doi/10.2105/AJPH.2026.308505)

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Original text here: https://www.ewg.org/research/how-food-became-flavor-business-history-ultra-processed-food

[Category: Environment]

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